Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

March 6, 2002

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 02S35 – 2002 Model Year Th!nk Neighbor – Brake Master Cylinder Pushrod Fractures

Summary

- Ford Action – Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall involving all 2002 model year Th!nk Neighbor vehicles, built from October 22, 2001 through February 21, 2002, relating to a possible fracture of the brake master cylinder pushrod.

- Number of Vehicles Involved – Approximately 735 vehicles in the United States and none in Canada.

- Affect on Vehicle Operation – In some of the affected vehicles, the brake master cylinder pushrod, which connects the brake pedal to the master cylinder, may fracture in the field. Fracture of the pushrod would result in the loss of the service brakes. This condition would not affect the manual parking brake, which is sufficient to bring the vehicle to a complete stop.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will be instructed to stop demonstrating and delivering vehicles until the brake master cylinder pushrod has been replaced with a redesigned pushrod assembly.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 -- Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
02S35 5d/pcw

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 – DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
02S35 – 2002 MODEL YEAR TH!NK NEIGHBOR

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

All 2002 Model Year Th!nk Neighbor vehicles built from October 22, 2001 through February 21, 2002 at the Detroit Chassis Plant are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 735 Th!nk Neighbor vehicles in the United States.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

All of the involved vehicles have the subject brake master cylinder pushrod.

573.5 (c) (5) -- Description of the Defect

The brake master cylinder pushrod was manufactured to an improper tolerance specification, which can lead to the pushrod contacting the brake pedal arm during full stroke of the pedal. This condition may lead to bending, and in some cases, fracture of the pushrod.

Ford is aware of two confirmed reports of brake master cylinder pushrod fractures. There have been no reported accidents or injuries or fires attributed to this condition.

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

Ford first became aware of this condition on January 22, 2002, with a reported brake master cylinder pushrod fracture at an authorized Th!nk dealer. Engineering was dispatched to assess the vehicle. Engineering instituted a test program to evaluate the fractured component, which determined that the component met all specified strength requirements.

On February 18, 2002, a second fractured brake master cylinder pushrod was reported. An analysis of this component and the brake mechanism concluded that an improper tolerance on the threaded portion of the pushrod led to the pushrod contacting the brake pedal arm during full stroke of the pedal. This contact caused the pushrod to bend in front of the clevis bracket, resulting in a fracture of the pushrod.

There are no known accidents or injuries attributed to this condition.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Ford has notified all authorized Th!nk dealers to stop demonstrating and delivering vehicles until the brake master cylinder pushrod has been replaced with a redesigned pushrod assembly.

There will be no charge to owners for this service.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning the subject matter of this action. A copy of the Notification letters to dealers and owners from Ford will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 02S35 to this action.